Class 8 Social Science – Chapter 4

The Colonial Era in India

NCERT • Exploring Society: India and Beyond • Part 1 • Simple English Question–Answers

इस अध्याय के सभी मुख्य टॉपिक्स, पाठ के अंत में दिए गए प्रश्नों के उत्तर और परीक्षा के लिए महत्वपूर्ण संभावित प्रश्न–उत्तर नीचे सरल अंग्रेजी में दिए गए हैं। उत्तर आपकी कक्षा 8 की PDF के आधार पर तैयार किए गए हैं।

Part 1: Important Questions and Answers from Every Topic

Topic 1: The Age of Colonialism

Q1. What is colonialism?

Answer: Colonialism is the practice in which one country takes control of another region. It imposes its political, economic and cultural systems on the people living there.

Q2. What was the Age of Colonialism?

Answer: The Age of Colonialism usually refers to the period from the 15th century onwards, when European countries conquered and controlled many parts of the world.

Q3. Which European countries established colonies around the world?

Answer: Spain, Portugal, Britain, France and the Netherlands established colonies in different parts of the world.

Q4. Why did European countries want colonies?

Answer: They wanted natural resources, new markets, trade routes, political power and wealth. Some also wanted to spread Christianity and explore unknown lands.

Q5. What was the so-called ‘civilising mission’?

Answer: European rulers claimed that they were bringing progress and civilisation to other people. In reality, colonial rule often caused exploitation, loss of independence and destruction of traditional ways of life.

Q6. What were the effects of colonialism on colonised people?

Answer: Colonialism caused economic exploitation, loss of political freedom, cultural changes and great hardship. Most benefits went to the colonial rulers.

Q7. What is meant by enslavement?

Answer: Enslavement means forcing a person to live as a slave without freedom.

Topic 2: India Before European Colonial Rule

Q1. Why was India attractive to European powers?

Answer: India was rich in goods, natural resources and skilled industries. Its spices, cotton textiles, ivory, gems, sandalwood and steel were in great demand.

Q2. What was India's economic position before European colonial rule?

Answer: India was one of the world's largest economies. Historical estimates suggest that it produced at least one-fourth of the world's GDP during the period described in the chapter.

Q3. Which Indian goods were popular in foreign markets?

Answer: Indian spices, cotton cloth, silk, ivory, gems, sandalwood, teakwood and wootz steel were popular in foreign markets.

Q4. Did India trade with foreign countries before the arrival of Europeans?

Answer: Yes. India had trade relations with the Greeks and Romans more than two thousand years ago.

Topic 3: The Portuguese – Commerce and Atrocities

Q1. Who was Vasco da Gama?

Answer: Vasco da Gama was a Portuguese explorer who arrived at Kappad, near Kozhikode in Kerala, in May 1498.

Q2. Why was Vasco da Gama's arrival important?

Answer: His arrival opened the way for European colonial expansion in India.

Q3. Why did the Portuguese capture Goa?

Answer: They captured Goa in 1510 because it was an important strategic port. It later became the capital of their Indian colony.

Q4. What was the cartaz system?

Answer: The cartaz system required ships sailing in the Arabian Sea to buy Portuguese permits. Ships without permits could be seized.

Q5. What was the Goa Inquisition?

Answer: The Goa Inquisition was established in 1560. It persecuted people suspected of following religious beliefs different from those accepted by the Church.

Q6. Who was Rani Abbakka I?

Answer: Rani Abbakka I was the ruler of Ullal in present-day Karnataka. She formed alliances with neighbouring kingdoms and resisted repeated Portuguese attempts to capture her territory.

Topic 4: The Dutch – Commerce and Competition

Q1. When did the Dutch arrive in India?

Answer: The Dutch arrived in India in the early 17th century.

Q2. What was the main aim of the Dutch in India?

Answer: Their main aim was to control trade, especially the spice trade.

Q3. Name some Dutch trading centres in India.

Answer: Their trading centres included Surat, Bharuch, Cochin, Nagapattinam and Masulipatnam.

Q4. What was the Battle of Colachel?

Answer: The Battle of Colachel took place in 1741. King Marthanda Varma of Travancore defeated the Dutch forces on land and at sea.

Q5. Why was the Battle of Colachel important?

Answer: It was a rare example of an Asian power successfully defeating a European colonial force. After this defeat, Dutch power in India declined.

Topic 5: The French – Colonial Ambitions

Q1. When did the French establish their first trading post in India?

Answer: The French established their first trading post at Surat in 1668.

Q2. Where did the French establish an important settlement in 1674?

Answer: They established an important settlement at Pondicherry, now called Puducherry, in 1674.

Q3. Who was Dupleix?

Answer: Dupleix was the Governor-General of French India from 1742 to 1754. He tried to build a French empire in India.

Q4. What were sepoys?

Answer: Sepoys were Indian soldiers trained and organised using European military techniques.

Q5. What was indirect rule?

Answer: Indirect rule was a system in which a colonial power controlled a territory through local rulers who depended on it.

Q6. What were the Carnatic Wars?

Answer: The Carnatic Wars were a series of conflicts between Britain and France from 1746 to 1763. The French eventually lost ground to the British.

Q7. What happened to French power in India?

Answer: French control was reduced mainly to Pondicherry and a few smaller settlements. The French failed to establish a large empire in India.

Topic 6: The British East India Company – From Traders to Rulers

Q1. When was the English East India Company established?

Answer: The English East India Company was established in 1600 and received a royal charter from Queen Elizabeth I.

Q2. What special powers did the East India Company receive?

Answer: It received special trading privileges and powers, including the right to maintain a private army.

Q3. Name four important early British trading centres in India.

Answer: Surat, Madras, Bombay and Calcutta were important early British trading centres.

Q4. How did the East India Company become a political power?

Answer: The Company first came as a trader. It then made alliances with Indian rulers, interfered in their disputes, used its army and gradually captured territories.

Q5. What was the policy of ‘divide and rule’?

Answer: It was a policy of creating or using divisions among Indian rulers and communities to make British control easier.

Q6. Explain the Battle of Plassey.

Answer: The Battle of Plassey was fought in 1757 between the forces of Siraj-ud-daulah, the Nawab of Bengal, and the East India Company led by Robert Clive. Mir Jafar, the Nawab's military commander, betrayed the Nawab by keeping his forces out of the fight. The British won the battle and increased their control over Bengal.

Q7. Why is Mir Jafar remembered as a traitor?

Answer: Mir Jafar secretly worked with Robert Clive and did not support Siraj-ud-daulah during the Battle of Plassey. Therefore, his name became a symbol of betrayal.

Q8. What was the Doctrine of Lapse?

Answer: Under the Doctrine of Lapse, the British annexed a princely state if its ruler died without a natural male heir. The policy disregarded the Indian tradition of adoption.

Q9. What was a princely state?

Answer: A princely state was a region ruled by an Indian prince, maharaja or nawab who accepted British protection but retained some internal authority.

Q10. What was the Subsidiary Alliance?

Answer: Under the Subsidiary Alliance, an Indian ruler had to maintain British troops at the ruler's own expense and conduct foreign relations through the British. A British Resident was also placed at the ruler's court.

Q11. How did the Subsidiary Alliance help the British?

Answer: It allowed the British to control Indian states without directly administering all their territories. It also weakened the independence of Indian rulers.

Topic 7: Devastating Famines

Q1. What caused the Bengal famine of 1770–1772?

Answer: The famine followed two years of crop failure. Heavy land taxes imposed by the East India Company, even during the famine, made the suffering much worse.

Q2. How severe was the Bengal famine?

Answer: The chapter estimates that nearly one-third of Bengal's population, or about 10 million people, died.

Q3. How did the Company treat farmers during the famine?

Answer: It continued to demand high land taxes regardless of the harvest. This placed a terrible burden on farmers who had little or no food.

Q4. What happened during the Great Famine of 1876–1878?

Answer: Up to eight million Indians died, mostly in the Deccan Plateau, according to the chapter.

Q5. How did British economic policies worsen famines?

Answer: The British continued exporting grain, collected taxes during food shortages and followed a free-market policy that allowed food prices to rise. Relief camps were also too few and poorly supplied.

Q6. What does the chapter say about the long-term effect of famines?

Answer: Famines caused enormous loss of life and pushed many people, especially in rural India, into deep poverty.

Topic 8: The Drain of India's Wealth

Q1. What is meant by the ‘drain of India's wealth’?

Answer: It means the transfer of India's wealth to Britain through taxes, trade, colonial expenses and other payments, without a fair benefit to the Indian people.

Q2. Who was Dadabhai Naoroji?

Answer: Dadabhai Naoroji was an Indian political leader who studied how British rule drained wealth from India. He wrote Poverty and Un-British Rule in India in 1901.

Q3. Who was Romesh Chunder Dutt?

Answer: Romesh Chunder Dutt was a historian who studied the economic effects of British rule in India. His book was called Economic History of India.

Q4. How did Britain benefit from India's wealth?

Answer: India's wealth helped finance British economic growth. The chapter discusses the argument that wealth taken from India contributed to Britain's Industrial Revolution.

Q5. How did Indians pay for British colonial rule?

Answer: Indians paid through taxes and through the cost of railways, telegraph networks, wars, the colonial administration and British military installations.

Q6. What did Dadabhai Naoroji mean by ‘Un-British Rule’?

Answer: He meant that British rule in India went against the principles of fairness and justice that Britain claimed to support. It exploited India instead of serving its people.

Topic 9: Decline of India's Indigenous Industries

Q1. What were India's main industries before British rule?

Answer: India was famous for cotton, silk, wool, jute, hemp and coir textiles. It also produced iron, steel, paper and other goods.

Q2. How did British policies damage Indian textile industries?

Answer: Britain imposed heavy duties on Indian textiles entering Britain but allowed British manufactured goods to enter India with low tariffs. This made it difficult for Indian producers to compete.

Q3. What happened to Indian artisans and weavers?

Answer: Many artisans and weavers lost their livelihoods and became poor. Some had to return to subsistence farming.

Q4. What was the result of the decline of Indian industries?

Answer: India's manufacturing sector weakened, imports of British goods increased and India's share of world GDP fell sharply.

Q5. What did William Bentinck mean by his statement about the bones of cotton weavers?

Answer: His statement described the extreme suffering and poverty of Indian cotton weavers caused by the decline of their traditional industry.

Topic 10: Dismantling Traditional Governance Structures

Q1. How were Indian villages governed before British rule?

Answer: Village councils managed local affairs, settled disputes and organised public works such as irrigation and roads.

Q2. What changes did the British make to local administration?

Answer: They replaced many traditional systems with a centralised bureaucracy mainly designed to collect taxes and maintain order.

Q3. How did British laws affect Indian communities?

Answer: British laws often ignored customary laws and practices. Courts could be expensive, slow and difficult for ordinary Indians to understand because they used a foreign language.

Q4. What did Charles Metcalfe say about village communities?

Answer: He described village communities as small, self-sufficient republics that survived even when dynasties and kingdoms changed.

Topic 11: Transforming Indian Education

Q1. What types of educational institutions existed in India before British rule?

Answer: India had pathshalas, madrasas, viharas and apprenticeship systems. They taught practical knowledge as well as cultural values.

Q2. What was Macaulay's Minute on Indian Education?

Answer: It was a statement issued in 1835 by Thomas B. Macaulay. He supported European-style education and believed that European knowledge was superior to Indian learning.

Q3. What did Macaulay want to achieve through English education?

Answer: He wanted to create a class of Indians who would work for the British administration and adopt English tastes, opinions and values.

Q4. How did British education affect traditional Indian schools?

Answer: Traditional schools gradually declined, while English became a language of prestige. This increased the gap between English-educated Indians and the masses.

Q5. What is an Orientalist?

Answer: In this chapter, an Orientalist is a scholar who studies the languages, literature and cultures of Asian regions. In India, many studied Sanskrit, Pali, Persian and other languages.

Q6. Why did the British need English-educated Indians?

Answer: They needed Indian clerks and junior officials to work in the colonial administration at a lower cost than British employees.

Topic 12: Reshaping the Indian Economy

Q1. How did British rule change India's economy?

Answer: India was increasingly turned into a supplier of raw materials for British industries and a market for British manufactured goods.

Q2. Why did the British build railways in India?

Answer: Railways helped transport raw materials to ports, distribute British goods across India and move troops quickly to deal with rebellions or wars.

Q3. Did the railways benefit India?

Answer: Railways connected regions and helped integrate India's internal market. However, the chapter explains that they were designed mainly to serve British commercial and military interests.

Q4. Who paid for the construction of railways and the telegraph network?

Answer: Much of their cost was paid from Indian tax revenue.

Q5. Explain the statement, “Indians funded their own subjugation.”

Answer: Indians paid taxes that financed the British administration, army and infrastructure. These systems were often used to control India and protect British interests.

Topic 13: The Sannyasi–Fakir Rebellion

Q1. What was the Sannyasi–Fakir Rebellion?

Answer: It was an early resistance movement that began in Bengal after the famine of 1770. Hindu sannyasis and Muslim fakirs resisted restrictions and harsh Company policies.

Q2. Why did the sannyasis and fakirs oppose the British?

Answer: British policies restricted their traditional movements for pilgrimage and charity. New land and taxation policies also contributed to their opposition.

Q3. How did the British respond to this rebellion?

Answer: The British called the rebels bandits, executed some of them and eventually defeated the movement with their stronger forces.

Q4. How did this rebellion influence Indian nationalism?

Answer: It later inspired Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's novel Anandamath (1882), which included the song ‘Vande Mataram’. The song inspired Indians during the freedom struggle and later became India's national song.

Topic 14: Tribal Uprisings

Q1. Why did tribal communities resist British rule?

Answer: The British restricted access to forests, took tribal lands, imposed taxes, encouraged debt, weakened traditional councils and interfered with tribal ways of life.

Q2. What was the Kol Uprising?

Answer: The Kol Uprising of 1831–1832 took place in Chota Nagpur, in present-day Jharkhand. It began after British land policies favoured outsiders over tribal inhabitants.

Q3. What was the Santhal Rebellion?

Answer: The Santhal Rebellion of 1855–1856 was a major tribal uprising in parts of present-day Jharkhand, Bihar and West Bengal.

Q4. Who led the Santhal Rebellion?

Answer: Two brothers, Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu, led the rebellion.

Q5. Why did the Santhals rebel?

Answer: Moneylenders and landlords, supported by the British system, were taking away their ancestral lands.

Q6. How did the British respond to the Santhal Rebellion?

Answer: The British response was brutal. They burned villages and killed thousands of Santhals, including the rebel leaders.

Topic 15: Peasant Uprisings and the Indigo Revolt

Q1. Why did peasants oppose British revenue policies?

Answer: High and unfair taxes made it difficult for peasants to survive. Many lost their land to moneylenders or landlords.

Q2. What was the Indigo Revolt?

Answer: The Indigo Revolt of 1859–1862 was a peasant uprising against European planters who forced farmers in northern Bengal to grow indigo instead of food crops.

Q3. Why was indigo important to European planters?

Answer: Indigo was a natural blue dye that was in great demand in Europe.

Q4. How were indigo farmers exploited?

Answer: Farmers were paid very little and often fell into debt. Those who refused to grow indigo faced imprisonment, torture and destruction of their property.

Q5. Who supported the indigo farmers?

Answer: Educated Bengalis and the Bengali press supported their cause. British authorities were eventually forced to restrict some of the worst abuses.

Topic 16: The Great Rebellion of 1857

Q1. What was the Great Rebellion of 1857?

Answer: It was a major uprising against British rule. Indian soldiers and other groups rebelled in northern and central India. The British called it the ‘Sepoy Mutiny’, but many historians prefer the term ‘Great Rebellion of 1857’.

Q2. What was the Vellore Mutiny of 1806?

Answer: It was an uprising by Indian soldiers at Vellore in present-day Tamil Nadu. The British had introduced uniform rules that violated Hindu and Muslim religious practices. The British crushed the revolt.

Q3. What was the immediate cause of the Rebellion of 1857?

Answer: Rumours spread that rifle cartridges were greased with cow and pig fat. This offended the religious beliefs of Hindu and Muslim soldiers.

Q4. Who was Mangal Pandey?

Answer: Mangal Pandey was an Indian sepoy who attacked British officers at Barrackpore in 1857. His execution increased anger among Indian soldiers.

Q5. Who was Bahadur Shah Zafar?

Answer: Bahadur Shah Zafar was the last Mughal emperor. The rebels proclaimed him their leader during the uprising of 1857.

Q6. Name some important centres of the Rebellion of 1857.

Answer: Important centres included Delhi, Kanpur, Lucknow and Jhansi.

Q7. Why did the Rebellion of 1857 fail?

Answer: According to some historians, the rebels lacked a unified command and a consistent strategy. The British also had strong military resources.

Q8. How did the British respond to the rebellion?

Answer: The British used extreme violence. They carried out executions, massacres, burned villages and destroyed crops to crush the rebellion.

Q9. What was the result of the Rebellion of 1857?

Answer: The rebellion failed, but it became an important turning point in the struggle against foreign rule. In 1858, the British Crown took direct control of India from the East India Company.

Q10. Who was Rani Lakshmibai?

Answer: Rani Lakshmibai was the queen of Jhansi. She fought bravely against British annexation, escaped from besieged Jhansi and continued fighting. She died on the battlefield on 18 June 1858.

Q11. Who was Begum Hazrat Mahal?

Answer: Begum Hazrat Mahal was a leader of the resistance in Awadh. She led the defence of Lucknow during the rebellion and later took refuge in Nepal.

Q12. Who was Tatia Tope?

Answer: Tatia Tope was a military adviser to Nana Saheb and an important rebel leader. He continued fighting the British until he was betrayed and hanged.

Q13. What changed after 1857?

Answer: In 1858, the British Crown took direct control of India. The British reorganised the Indian Army and focused more on strengthening and maintaining their rule.

Topic 17: The Legacy of European Colonialism in India

Q1. What was the main legacy of European colonialism in India?

Answer: Colonialism caused political subjugation, economic exploitation, poverty, violence and the disruption of traditional ways of life.

Q2. How did colonial rule affect Indian cultural heritage?

Answer: British and other European officials studied Indian monuments, art and architecture. However, many statues, paintings, jewels and manuscripts were also taken from India and sent to European museums or private collections.

Q3. Did colonial rule have any unintended consequences?

Answer: Yes. It increased contact between India and Europe. European scholars studied Indian languages, literature and monuments. Some Indian cultural works gained recognition in Europe.

Q4. How did Indian literature influence Europe?

Answer: European translations of Sanskrit texts introduced Indian ideas to European scholars, writers and philosophers. Indian literature influenced intellectual and cultural life in Europe and the United States.

Q5. Who translated the Bhagavad Gita into English in 1785?

Answer: Charles Wilkins translated the Bhagavad Gita into English in 1785.

Q6. What does the phrase ‘the jewel in the crown’ mean in this chapter?

Answer: It means that India was one of the most valuable colonies of the British Empire because of its wealth and resources.

Part 2: Answers to All Textbook Questions and Activities

These are the ten questions and activities given at the end of the chapter, with simple English answers.

Q1. What is colonialism? Give three different definitions.

Answer:

1. Colonialism is when one country takes political control of another region.
2. It is a system in which a foreign power exploits another country's resources and people.
3. It is the establishment of foreign control over a region's government, economy and culture.

Q2. Colonial rulers claimed that they wanted to ‘civilise’ people. Was this true in India? Why or why not?

Answer: No, this claim was not true in the case of India. The British claimed that they were bringing progress, but they exploited India's wealth, imposed heavy taxes, damaged Indian industries and weakened traditional institutions. Their main aim was to protect their own interests.

Q3. How was the British approach to colonising India different from that of the Portuguese or the French?

Answer: The British gradually changed from traders into rulers. They used political alliances, the policy of divide and rule, military power, the Doctrine of Lapse and the Subsidiary Alliance. The Portuguese focused strongly on maritime trade and religious conversion, while the French tried to build an empire but lost ground to the British.

Q4. “Indians funded their own subjugation.” What does this mean in the context of railways and telegraph networks?

Answer: It means that much of the cost of building railways and the telegraph network came from Indian taxes. These systems mainly helped the British transport raw materials, sell their goods, move troops and control India.

Q5. What does ‘divide and rule’ mean? Give examples.

Answer: ‘Divide and rule’ means creating or using divisions among people to maintain control over them.

Examples:

- The British supported some Indian rulers against their rivals.
- Robert Clive made a secret agreement with Mir Jafar before the Battle of Plassey.
- The British used disputes within royal families to increase their power.
- They sometimes encouraged tensions between religious communities.

Q6. Choose one area of Indian life and explain how colonial rule affected it. Are its effects still visible today?

Answer: Education

British rule changed India's traditional education system. Macaulay's education policy of 1835 promoted European knowledge and English education. Traditional schools gradually declined, and English became important for government jobs and social status.

Some effects are still visible today. English remains important in higher education, administration and many professions. However, India also continues to teach through its many regional languages and educational traditions.

Q7. Imagine you are a reporter in 1857. Write a news report on Rani Lakshmibai's resistance at Jhansi. Include a timeline.

Rani Lakshmibai Fights the British at Jhansi

Date: 1857–1858

Jhansi: Rani Lakshmibai has bravely resisted British attempts to take control of her kingdom. She joined the uprising against British rule and defended Jhansi with courage. When British forces attacked, she escaped from the besieged city and continued the struggle with her supporters.

She later captured the Gwalior fort with the help of rebel forces. Rani Lakshmibai died fighting the British on 18 June 1858. Her courage made her one of the most remembered leaders of the Rebellion of 1857.

Timeline

- **1857:** The Great Rebellion begins.
- **1857–1858:** Rani Lakshmibai resists British control of Jhansi.
- **1858:** She escapes from Jhansi and continues fighting.
- **18 June 1858:** She dies on the battlefield.

Q8. Imagine India was never colonised by European powers. Write a short story of about 300 words.

India Without European Colonial Rule

Imagine a different history in which European powers never colonised India. Indian kingdoms and regional powers would have continued to develop through trade, agriculture, science and education.

Indian merchants might have expanded trade with Asia, Africa and Europe on their own terms. Indian textile industries could have continued producing fine cotton and silk fabrics for world

markets. Skilled artisans might have developed new machines and methods while preserving traditional crafts.

Indian rulers might have competed with one another, but they could also have formed alliances to protect trade and maintain peace. Universities, pathshalas, madrasas and other centres of learning might have grown according to local needs. Indian languages and classical literature would have continued to play an important role in education.

Railways, modern industries and new technologies might still have developed through Indian investment, international trade and scientific discoveries. Different regions could have followed different paths of development.

However, India would not necessarily have been free from every problem. Wars, political conflicts, poverty and social inequalities might still have existed. The future would have depended on the choices made by Indian rulers, scholars, traders and ordinary people.

In this imagined history, India develops through its own decisions and exchanges with the world rather than under foreign colonial control. It reminds us that a country's future depends greatly on its freedom to decide its own path.

Q9. Write a role-play between a British official and Dadabhai Naoroji.

A Discussion on British Rule in India

British Official: We have introduced railways, telegraphs and a new system of administration in India.

Dadabhai Naoroji: These facilities may have some benefits, but much of their cost has been paid by Indian taxpayers.

British Official: The British government also maintains law and order.

Dadabhai Naoroji: But heavy taxes and unfair economic policies have made many Indians poor.

British Official: British trade has connected India with world markets.

Dadabhai Naoroji: Indian industries have suffered because British manufactured goods receive favourable treatment. Indian wealth is also being transferred to Britain.

British Official: What changes do you want?

Dadabhai Naoroji: I want fair economic policies, greater Indian participation in administration and an end to the drain of India's wealth.

British Official: Your arguments raise important questions about the fairness of our rule.

Dadabhai Naoroji: India's resources should be used for the welfare and development of its own people.

Q10. Explore a local resistance movement from your state or region.

The following is an example based on the Santhal Rebellion, which affected parts of present-day Bihar, Jharkhand and West Bengal.

Report on the Santhal Rebellion (1855–1856)

1. What caused the movement?

The Santhals lost their ancestral lands because of exploitation by moneylenders and landlords, who received support from the British system.

2. Who led the movement?

The rebellion was led by two brothers, Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu.

3. What were their demands?

They wanted to protect their ancestral lands, resist exploitation and free their communities from oppressive control.

4. How did the British respond?

The British used military force to suppress the rebellion. They burned villages and killed thousands of Santhals, including the rebel leaders.

5. How is the movement remembered today?

The Santhal Rebellion is remembered as an important struggle for land, dignity and freedom. Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu are honoured as tribal freedom fighters.

Part 3: Extra Important Exam Questions

These questions cover key facts, comparisons, causes and consequences from the chapter.

Very Short Answer Questions

Q1. In which year did Vasco da Gama arrive in India?

Answer: 1498.

Q2. In which year did the Battle of Plassey take place?

Answer: 1757.

Q3. Who led the British forces at Plassey?

Answer: Robert Clive.

Q4. Who defeated the Dutch at the Battle of Colachel?

Answer: King Marthanda Varma of Travancore.

Q5. When did Macaulay issue his Minute on Indian Education?

Answer: 1835.

Q6. When did the British Crown take direct control of India?

Answer: 1858.

Q7. Who led the Santhal Rebellion?

Answer: Sidhu and Kanhu Murmu.

Q8. When did the Indigo Revolt take place?

Answer: 1859–1862.

Q9. Who wrote Poverty and Un-British Rule in India?

Answer: Dadabhai Naoroji.

Q10. Who translated the Bhagavad Gita into English in 1785?

Answer: Charles Wilkins.

Short Answer Questions

Q1. Why did the British want to control Indian trade?

Answer: India had valuable goods, skilled industries and extensive trade networks. Controlling Indian trade allowed the British to gain wealth and markets for British products.

Q2. How did the British weaken Indian rulers?

Answer: They interfered in succession disputes, supported rival rulers, imposed Subsidiary Alliances and annexed states under the Doctrine of Lapse.

Q3. How did colonial rule affect farmers?

Answer: Heavy land taxes and unfair revenue policies placed farmers under great pressure. Many lost their land, fell into debt and suffered during famines.

Q4. How did colonial rule affect tribal communities?

Answer: It restricted their access to forests, disrupted their traditional life, took away land and weakened their customary systems of governance.

Q5. Why is the Rebellion of 1857 considered a turning point?

Answer: Although the rebellion failed, it challenged British authority and encouraged the idea that foreign domination should end. It also led to the end of East India Company rule in 1858.

Long Answer Questions

Q1. Explain the main methods used by the British to establish control over India.

Answer: The British used several methods to establish control over India. First, the East India Company established trading posts along the coast. It then interfered in political disputes among Indian rulers. The policy of divide and rule helped the British defeat their rivals. The victory at the Battle of Plassey in 1757 increased their power in Bengal. The Doctrine of Lapse and the Subsidiary Alliance helped them annex or control more Indian states. Their military strength and political strategies eventually made them the dominant colonial power in India.

Q2. Explain the major economic effects of British colonial rule.

Answer: British colonial rule caused serious economic changes in India. Heavy taxes placed a burden on farmers and contributed to severe suffering during famines. British trade policies weakened Indian textile industries and other traditional manufactures. India increasingly supplied raw materials to British industries and became a market for British goods. Indian taxes also paid for railways, telegraphs, the army and the colonial administration. As a result, many Indians became poorer and India's share of world GDP declined sharply.

Q3. Describe the major forms of resistance against British colonial rule discussed in the chapter.

Answer: Several groups resisted British rule. The Sannyasi–Fakir Rebellion began in Bengal after the famine of 1770. Tribal communities rose against land policies and interference in their traditional lives, as seen in the Kol Uprising and Santhal Rebellion. Peasants protested against exploitation by indigo planters during the Indigo Revolt. The Great Rebellion of 1857 involved Indian soldiers and other groups in several regions. Although many movements were suppressed, they showed the widespread opposition to colonial rule.

Quick Revision: Important Dates

Year	Event
1498	Vasco da Gama arrived in India
1510	Portuguese captured Goa
1560	Goa Inquisition established
1674	French trading settlement at Pondicherry
1741	Battle of Colachel
1757	Battle of Plassey
1770–1772	Great Bengal famine
1806	Vellore Mutiny
1831–1832	Kol Uprising
1835	Macaulay's Minute on Indian Education
1855–1856	Santhal Rebellion
1857	Great Rebellion of 1857
1858	British Crown took direct control of India
1859–1862	Indigo Revolt

Exam tip: First learn the definitions, important dates, causes and effects of colonialism, the difference between the European powers, and the main resistance movements. These topics provide a strong foundation for answering both short and long questions.